

A FRAMEWORK IN CHAPTERS

Chapter Three

Adultism

*The system that ranks adults above the young
A Fundamental Matrix*

Adultism is the system that ranks adults above the young, extracts obedience and caretaking from anyone under the adult line, and removes the young's option to make decisions about their own bodies, time, and futures. This chapter runs it through the five domains — from the compound to the Child Rights Act to the slow death of the obedient Nigerian child's inner voice.

CONTEXT	Nigeria
VOLUME	A Framework for Understanding Systemic Oppression
DATE	June 2026

CHAPTER 3 OF AN ONGOING FRAMEWORK

Adultism

Adultism overlaps with Rankism at every point — the young are the most universal ‘juniors’ — but the two matrices are not the same. Rankism ranks by position. Adultism ranks by age. The framework separates them so that both can be dismantled. This chapter follows the same matrix-chapter template established in Chapter 2.

A note on the framework’s own classification rule from Chapter 1: children and babies only count as subjects of Adultism because they are in the same class with teenagers, who meet the comprehension test. The analogy is to Somatic Normativity: a fully paralysed person shares the ‘disabled’ class with someone who simply has a bad leg. The class is the analytical unit, not the individual case.

A note on method. The Interpersonal, Disciplinary, and Structural sections take the naive approach — each triad described as if happening for the first time, with no networks, residues, or Canon referenced. The Hegemonic Domain section is where Canon and Practice finally enter the picture.

READING NOTE

Same convention as Chapters 1 and 2. Every paragraph is written to be tweetable. Where you see literal blanks (____), the framework is asking you to write yourself into it. The blanks are the difference between reading about Adultism and locating yourself inside it.

Contents

Adultism	1
Contents	1
1. Definition: What Adultism Extracts, Enforces, and Removes	3
1.1 What Adultism Extracts	3
1.2 What Adultism Enforces	3
1.3 What Options Adultism Removes	4
2. The Interpersonal Domain	5
3.1 Enforcement Triad: Compliance Standard	5
3.2 Enforcement Triad: Silence Standard	5
3.3 Enforcement Triad: Presence Standard	6
3.4 Enforcement Triad: Schedule Standard	6
3.5 Extraction Triad: Obedience Labour	7

3.6 Extraction Triad: Caretaking Labour	7
3.7 Extraction Triad: Deference	8
3.8 Extraction Triad: Future Potential	8
3. The Disciplinary Domain	10
4.1 Disciplinary Hierarchy — Nested Stars	10
4.2 Disciplinary Community — Distributed Network	11
4. The Structural Domain	13
5.1 Bureaucracy — Enduring Rules and Procedures	13
5.2 Stratification — Enduring Zero-Sum Rankings	13
5.3 Classification — Enduring Categorical Divisions	14
5. The Hegemonic Domain: The Ascension Ritual	15
6.1 Canon — Rewriting History	15
6.2 Practice — Rewriting Reality	17
6. When Did Adultism Rewrite History?	19
7. Fill in the Blank: A Self-Examination	20
Question 1: When did Adultism rewrite your reality?	20
Question 2: How is Adultism causing your Death?	20
8. Endnotes & References	21
Coming Next	22

SECTION 1

1. Definition: What Adulthood Extracts, Enforces, and Removes

Adulthood is the system that ranks adults above the young and treats anyone under the adult line as incapable of competent decision-making. The word was used in this sense by the educator John Holt in *Escape from Childhood* (1974) and the psychologist Richard Farson in *Birthrights* (1978). Holt argued that childhood is a status invented by adults to justify denying the young the rights of persons.

The framework uses Holt's and Farson's sense of the term. Adulthood is a fundamental matrix in its own right. It overlaps with Rankism (Chapter 2) because the young are the universal 'juniors'. But Adulthood's ranking principle is age, not position. A 40-year-old with no formal position is still ranked above a 16-year-old with one. The line is the body, not the office.

bell hooks, in *Feminism is for Everybody* (2000), called this 'patriarchal adulthood' — the default assumption in the patriarchal family that adults (especially adult men) have the right to command the young. Alison Gopnik's *The Gardener and the Carpenter* (2016) showed, from developmental psychology, that the young are far more competent decision-makers than Adulthood admits. The competence gap is real but smaller than the system claims.

1.1 What Adulthood Extracts

Adulthood extracts five things. First, **obedience labour**: the work of complying with adult instructions regardless of their merit. The young person's energy is spent in compliance, not in inquiry. Second, **caretaking labour**: the young are expected to provide emotional and physical care for adults, especially elders, often ahead of their own needs.

Third, **deference**: the labour of attention and body (kneeling, greeting, standing when an elder enters). Fourth, **academic labour**: in schools, the young produce the examination results, the sport victories, and the cultural capital that adults consume as institutional prestige. Fifth, **future potential**: the young's possible futures are extracted and channelled into adult-chosen tracks.

1.2 What Adulthood Enforces

Adulthood enforces four standards. First, **compliance**: the young must do what adults instruct. Second, **silence**: the young must not speak unless spoken to, must not interrupt, must not 'backchat'. Third, **presence**: the young must be where adults require them to be — in school, at the family event, in the church, in the kitchen.

Fourth, **schedule**: the young must keep adult-imposed schedules — bedtimes, school hours, prayer times, fasting periods, chore rosters. Sub-standards include dress (school uniforms, 'modest' clothing

for girls), diet (what the young may eat and when), and sexual abstinence (enforced by surveillance and punishment, with voting deliberately withheld as a marker of non-personhood).

1.3 What Options Adultism Removes

Concretely, Adultism removes the option to refuse school. The Child Rights Act 2003 (Nigeria) makes basic education compulsory. A child who refuses to attend is treated as delinquent. The young person who would rather learn a trade than sit in a classroom has no legal route to that choice until age 18.

It removes the option to refuse medical procedures. The young cannot consent to or refuse surgery, vaccination, or circumcision. Parents and guardians decide. The young person who does not want a procedure has no legal recourse. It removes the option to manage one's own money — the young cannot open a bank account, sign a contract, or own property in their own name until 18.

It removes the option to choose where to live, to leave, to consent to sex (the age of consent is 18 in most Nigerian states), to marry without parental permission (the Marriage Act sets 21, customary law varies), and to vote in elections (18). Each removal is enforced by law and by the interpersonal triads the law backs up. Paulo Freire, in *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* (1968), called this the 'banking' model of education — the young are containers to be filled, not persons to be consulted.

SECTION 2 · NAIVE APPROACH

2. The Interpersonal Domain

The Interpersonal Domain contains four enforcement triads and four extraction triads. Each is described here as if happening for the first time — no networks, no residues, no Canon. Just the act, the conforming subject, the complicit witness, and (for extraction triads) the Non-Extracting Beneficiary.

3.1 Enforcement Triad: Compliance Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands compliance with an instruction regardless of its merit. A parent, a teacher, a religious instructor, an older relative, or any adult in loco parentis could fill this role. The enforcement is performed by issuing the instruction, by signalling disapproval when the young person does not comply, or by punishing non-compliance after the fact.

The subject conforms by complying. The conforming act is the compliance itself — the young person does what they were told, even if they disagree, even if the instruction is harmful, even if no reason was given. The compliance is the proof of the system.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A 14-year-old who refuses to fetch water for an adult relative loses the right to remain in the household without conflict. A student who refuses to do pointless homework loses marks, which is to say, loses access to promotion, which is to say, loses access to the next stage of life. A daughter who refuses to marry the man her father has chosen loses the right to family support, sometimes to her life.

The witness is the person who hears the instruction and says nothing, or who themselves model compliance by obeying the same adult. The witness's complicity is structural: their silence tells the enforcer that the demand is legitimate, and tells the young person that compliance is the only safe option. The witness is not personally benefiting from the specific enforcement.

3.2 Enforcement Triad: Silence Standard

The enforcer is the person who requires the young person's silence. The parent who says 'children should be seen and not heard.' The teacher who punishes a student for asking a question outside the lesson plan. The uncle who tells the niece to be quiet when adults are speaking. The enforcement is performed by direct command, by interrupting, or by punishing 'backchat'.

The subject conforms by being silent. The conforming act is the absence of speech. The young person learns to withhold their question, their concern, their objection. The withholding becomes reflexive over time, until the young person no longer notices they are withholding.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A child who is silenced at the dinner table loses the option to report abuse — sometimes for years. A teenager who is silenced in the family meeting loses the

option to influence decisions about their own life. A student who is silenced in the classroom loses the option to ask for clarification, which is to say, loses the option to learn.

The witness is the person who watches the silencing and does not intervene, or who themselves remain silent as a model. The witness's complicity normalises the demand. The witness is the keeper of the 'children should be seen and not heard' convention — their silence is the convention.

3.3 Enforcement Triad: Presence Standard

The enforcer is the person who requires the young person's physical presence at a specified location. The parent who requires the child to be at the family event. The school that requires attendance. The church that requires the youth member at Sunday school. The enforcement is performed by direct command, by physical retrieval (dragging the young person to the location), or by punishing absence.

The subject conforms by being present. The conforming act is the body itself — the young person is where they were required to be, at the time they were required to be there. There is no argument to make against a presence demand that has already been met by the body's presence.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A teenager required to attend a six-hour Sunday service loses the option to rest, to study, to play, to develop their own spiritual life outside the enforced context. A child required to be at the family event loses the option to be with their friends, which is to say, loses the option to develop peer relationships on their own terms. A student required to be in school loses the option to learn elsewhere, even when elsewhere would serve them better.

The witness is the person who watches the presence demand and does not intervene, or who themselves were present at the same kind of event as a child and so model compliance. The witness's complicity is the shared memory of their own enforced presence — the 'we all went through it' that closes the loop.

3.4 Enforcement Triad: Schedule Standard

The enforcer is the person who imposes a schedule on the young person. The parent who sets the bedtime. The school that sets the bell times. The mosque that sets the prayer times. The enforcement is performed by direct command, by interruption (waking the sleeping child), or by punishing schedule violations.

The subject conforms by keeping the schedule. The conforming act is the timing itself — the young person is asleep when required, awake when required, in the bathroom when required, at the table when required. The schedule disciplines the body across the day.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A child whose bedtime is 8pm loses the option to develop their own relationship with sleep — which is to say, loses the option to learn self-regulation. A teenager whose every hour is scheduled loses the option to be bored, which is to say, loses the option to develop interior life. A boarding school student whose day runs from 5am to 10pm loses the option to be alone, which is to say, loses the option to know themselves.

The witness is the person who watches the schedule being imposed and does not intervene, or who themselves keep similar schedules as adults (workplace schedules are the adult continuation). The witness's complicity is the shared acceptance that the schedule is the natural shape of the day.

3.5 Extraction Triad: Obedience Labour

The extractor is the person who requires the young person to perform obedience as work. The parent who requires the child to fetch, carry, clean, and serve. The teacher who requires the student to perform attention, deference, and compliance. The elder who requires the young relative to run errands. The extraction is performed by summoning, by direct command, or simply by being present — the young person knows to obey.

The subject conforms by obeying. What is extracted is the labour of obedience itself — the energy spent in compliance, the attention spent in anticipation, the self-suppression spent in deference. This labour does not appear in any economic accounting. It is invisible. But it is real, and it is exhausting.

The options the subject loses are concrete. Every hour spent in obedience labour is an hour not spent on the subject's own development. Over years, the cumulative loss is the option to develop one's own interests, one's own skills, one's own relationships. The obedient child becomes the adult who has no interior life, because the interior was never given time to form.

The witness is the person who watches the obedience extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves performed the same obedience for the same adults. The witness's complicity is the shared 'I did it too' that closes the loop. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the adult sibling in the household who consumes the obedience labour (the younger sibling serves them too) but does not personally command it.

The role is unstable. The moment the older sibling begins to command the younger — 'go and fetch', 'clean this', 'do my share' — they become extractors. Most older siblings drift into extraction by early adolescence, because the felt entitlement grows with each received obedience.

3.6 Extraction Triad: Caretaking Labour

The extractor is the person who requires the young person to provide care for adults. The grandparent who requires the grandchild to provide physical care. The ill parent who requires the teenage daughter to nurse them. The emotionally fragile parent who requires the child to manage their feelings. The extraction is performed by expectation, by guilt, or by direct command.

The subject conforms by caretaking. What is extracted is the labour of physical and emotional care — feeding, bathing, lifting, listening, soothing, absorbing. The labour is real. It is the same labour adults perform in paid care work, except the young person is not paid and cannot leave.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The 14-year-old nursing her mother loses the option to attend school regularly, which is to say, loses the option to a future. The child managing a parent's emotions loses the option to develop their own emotional life, which is to say, becomes a kind of

emotional servant. The grandchild lifting the grandparent loses the option to a childhood body that is not already worn out.

The witness is the person who watches the caretaking extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves performed the same labour for the same adults. The witness's complicity is the shared 'that's what children are for' that closes the loop. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the adult in the household who is not directly commanding the care but who benefits from it — the uncle whose mother is being nursed by the granddaughter, freeing him from the work.

3.7 Extraction Triad: Deference

The extractor is the person who requires deference performance from the young. The greeting ritual, the kneeling, the standing when the adult enters, the 'good morning, sir/ma'. The extraction is performed by summoning, by signalling, or simply by being present — the young person knows to perform.

The subject conforms by performing. What is extracted is the labour of attention and body. The performance itself is the resource: the extractor is receiving the young person's subordination, in real time, as a kind of social calorie. Overlap with Rankism here is heavy; the distinction is that Adulthood's deference extraction is triggered by age, not by office.

The options the subject loses are concrete. Every minute spent in deference performance is a minute not spent on the young person's own life. Over years, the cumulative loss is the option to develop one's own attention, one's own body, one's own presence in the world. The young person becomes the kind of person who is always performing, never present.

The witness is the person who watches the performance and does not intervene, or who performs alongside the young person. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the adult visiting the household who is greeted with extra deference because they are seen with the adults, but who does not personally demand the deference.

3.8 Extraction Triad: Future Potential

The extractor is the person whose decision overrides the young person's possible futures. The parent who decides the child will be a doctor. The family that decides the daughter will marry at 16. The school that decides the student is 'not academic' and routes them to a trade. The extraction is performed by choosing on the young person's behalf, by withholding information about alternatives, or by actively blocking the young person's stated choice.

The subject conforms by accepting. What is extracted is the young person's possible future — the doctor they might have been if they had chosen, the marriage they might have made, the trade they might have learned. The extracted future is replaced by the adult's chosen track.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The 16-year-old married off loses the option to choose her own partner, which is to say, loses the option to a life she would have lived. The student routed to a

trade loses the option to go to university, which is to say, loses the option to a profession. The child of the family that decided she would be a doctor loses the option to be anything else, even when she would have been happier as something else.

The witness is the person who watches the future being extracted and does not intervene, or who themselves had their future extracted in the same way. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member whose status rises because the young person is being routed to a prestigious track — the family of the doctor benefits from the doctor's status — but who does not personally command the routing.

Nascent forms of this system include: 'Children should be seen and not heard', 'Because I said so', Talking over children, Patting heads, Dismissing concerns as 'a phase', Forced hugging of relatives, Corporal punishment, The silent treatment, 'Respect your elders', 'I know what's best for you', Restricting movement (curfew, grounding), Withholding information, 'No backchat', Treating teens as children, Ignoring teens in adult conversations, Dismissing teen opinions as 'naïve'.

SECTION 3 · NAIVE APPROACH

3. The Disciplinary Domain

When the eight triads above link into networks, Adultism scales. The link can be hierarchical (the enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above) or community-based (the witness at one triad becomes the enforcer at another). Both forms are visible in every Nigerian institution that deals with the young.

4.1 Disciplinary Hierarchy — Nested Stars

A Disciplinary Hierarchy is a chain of nested triads. The enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above. Each middle position is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below. Adultism spreads through this form in every Nigerian institution with an age-graded chain of command.

Peak Triad-Node

At the peak is the triad where the highest adult authority in the hierarchy enforces on the layer below. The peak enforcer has no adult above-them in this hierarchy, so the enforcement is the purest expression of adult authority at the top. The peak extracts obedience, caretaking, deference, and future-potential from the layer below, and enforces compliance, silence, presence, and schedule on them.

In a Nigerian secondary school, the peak triad is the Principal enforcing on Vice Principals and Senior Masters. In a family compound, the peak is the Patriarch or Matriarch enforcing on the adult children and their spouses. In a Pentecostal church, the peak is the Senior Pastor enforcing on the Youth Pastor. In a children's ward of a teaching hospital, the peak is the Consultant Paediatrician enforcing on Registrars.

Middle Triad-Nodes

The middle nodes are where the chain's character is clearest. Each middle enforcer is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below. The teacher who kneels for the Principal in the morning demands kneeling from students in the afternoon. The Youth Pastor who stands for the Senior Pastor at the altar demands standing from the Youth Members at the youth meeting.

The middle is where Adultism reproduces. The student subject of today is the enforcer of tomorrow — not necessarily as a teacher, but as a parent, an uncle, an aunt, a youth leader. The middle position teaches the subject to want the position above, which means learning to enforce on those below. By the time the young person becomes an adult, they have been disciplined by Adultism for two decades.

In the secondary school, the middle nodes run from Principal down through Vice Principal, Senior Master, Year Head, Class Teacher, Senior Prefect, Prefect, Senior Student, Junior Student. Each layer enforces compliance, silence, presence, and schedule on the layer below, and is in turn enforced on by the layer above.

Bottom Triad-Node

At the bottom is the triad where the lowest-ranked adult enforcer in the hierarchy enforces on the youngest subjects. The Class Teacher enforcing on the Junior Student. The Youth Member enforcing on a younger sibling at home. The Older Sibling enforcing on the Younger Sibling.

The bottom node is the most violent because the bottom enforcer has the most to prove and the least to lose by proving it. The Senior Student who was humiliated last year as a Junior reproduces the humiliation with interest this year as a Senior. The Older Sibling who was beaten as a child beats the Younger Sibling as a teenager. The chain runs from adult-enforced child to child-enforced child, and the bottom is where the violence is most concentrated.

The boarding school senior/junior culture is the textbook case. The 1991 Lagos secondary school drowning (cited in Chapter 2 as Rankism fast death) is also Adultism fast death. The Senior Students who ordered the Junior to swim across the pool were enforcers in the bottom triad-node of an Adultism hierarchy that ran from the Ministry of Education down through the Principal, the House Master, the Senior Prefect, the Senior Student, to the Junior Student who died.

4.2 Disciplinary Community — Distributed Network

A Disciplinary Community is a distributed network. There is no peak, no chain of command. There is only circulation. The witness of one triad becomes the enforcer, subject, or witness of another. Adultism spreads laterally through any adult who has witnessed adult authority being exercised on the young without dissenting.

The Village Aunty Network

Adultism spreads through community by the village aunty network. Any elder in the compound can discipline any child. The child who is corrected by an unrelated aunty in the morning is corrected again by their own parent at night, who has been told by the aunty. The pattern has jumped across household boundaries through the aunty's witnessing and reporting.

Religion amplifies this. The Sunday school teacher who tells the children to 'honour your father and mother' circulates the compliance and deference triads across thousands of households in a single Sunday. The Imam's Friday sermon on obedience to parents circulates the same triads across the mosque network. No central command issues the order. The pattern circulates by repeated witnessing.

PTA and Neighbourhood Networks

The Parent-Teacher Association is a community network for Adultism. Parents meet teachers and share enforcement techniques. The teacher's classroom standard becomes the parent's household standard. The parent's household standard becomes the teacher's classroom standard. The pattern circulates.

The neighbourhood network operates similarly. A parent who witnesses another parent discipline a child in the street is licensed to do the same to their own. The shared witnessing creates a community standard that no single parent issued. The standard is in the air.

The Age-Grade Society

Pre-colonial Nigerian societies had age-grade systems that did some of this work in a more formal way. The Igbo age grade, the Yoruba regberegbe, the Tiv age set organised people by age cohort and gave each cohort defined roles. The colonial encounter converted these into more fluid neighbourhood networks, but the lateral circulation of adult authority over the young remained.

The contemporary version is the secondary school peer culture, the NYSC camp age cohort, the youth fellowship at church. Each is a community in which Adulthood circulates laterally, with the older cohort enforcing on the younger, and the younger cohort absorbing the enforcement as preparation for their turn as enforcers.

SECTION 4 · NAIVE APPROACH

4. The Structural Domain

Run the Ship of Theseus test. When the people in the initial Adultism triads are dead and replaced, when the networks are disbanded and reform, what is consistent? What outlives both individuals and groups? What forces new individuals and groups to re-form into the same patterns — not because anyone instructs them to, but because the residue makes any other pattern costly or invisible?

Adultism leaves all three residues. It is one of the most total systems in the framework, alongside Rankism. Almost every Nigerian institution carries Bureaucracy, Stratification, and Classification from Adultism simultaneously. The sections below describe each.

5.1 Bureaucracy — Enduring Rules and Procedures

Adultism's bureaucracy is the codified age threshold. The Child Rights Act 2003 (Nigeria) sets 18 as the age of majority. Voting age: 18. Driving age: 18. Criminal responsibility: 10 (under the Criminal Code) and 7 (under the Penal Code for the North). Smoking and drinking age: 18. Schooling age: 6 to 15 (compulsory basic education). Banking age: 18 (no account without a guardian). Medical consent age: 18. Military enlistment: 18 (with parental consent).

The Marriage Act sets the marriage age at 21 without parental consent, with exceptions for customary and Islamic marriages that have created the inconsistencies the framework will examine in later chapters. The NYSC Act imposes a 30-year age cut-off for participation, after which a Certificate of Exemption is issued — an adultism-coded exclusion from the youth service.

The Children and Young Persons Act (originally the 1943 Ordinance, replicated in state laws after independence) establishes the juvenile court system and the principle that those under 17 are 'children or young persons' requiring different legal treatment. The Compulsory, Free Universal Basic Education Act 2004 makes school attendance legally enforceable. The original authors are mostly dead. The bureaucracy lives.

5.2 Stratification — Enduring Zero-Sum Rankings

Adultism's stratification is the daily experience of age rank in every institutional encounter.

Age-graded schools: JSS 1 to SS 3, with each year ranked above the next. Age cohorts in NYSC: the 30-and-under group is the service cohort; the over-30 group is the exempt cohort. Age-segregated housing: children's rooms separate from adult rooms, with the children's room often the smallest and most shared.

Age-based salary scales in junior roles: the entry-level graduate salary is the same for a 22-year-old and a 35-year-old new hire, but the path to the next grade is tied to years of service, so the 22-year-old will reach the next grade younger and the 35-year-old will retire at a lower grade. Age-tied privileges

like drinking (18), driving (18), and voting (18) stratify the population at the threshold.

The family dinner table enforces stratification without anyone issuing an order. The patriarch sits at the head. The adult sons sit next. The adult daughters-in-law sit next. The teenage children sit next. The youngest children sit at the far end, or in the kitchen, or on the floor. The seating is the age rank. Challenging the seating is challenging the rank.

The classroom enforces stratification by form line. The tallest (usually oldest) at the back. The shortest (usually youngest) at the front. The formation is the rank. The PE teacher does not need to announce it; the line self-organises by age.

5.3 Classification — Enduring Categorical Divisions

Adultism's classification is the set of categorical names that organise every Nigerian into adult and non-adult. **Adult** and **Child** are the universal pair: in law, in medicine, in education, in the family. **Senior** and **Junior** overlap with Rankism but carry an age dimension. **Mature** and **Immature** carry moral loading — the 'immature' young person is one whose judgment has been pre-emptively discounted.

Responsible and **Irresponsible** carry the same loading: the young person is presumed irresponsible until proven otherwise, and the proof is rarely accepted. **Grown** and **Young** in casual speech. The elder/young one binary appears in some form in every Nigerian language; the framework avoids the original terms by request, but the binary is universal.

The classification does the work before any individual enforcer shows up. A 15-year-old walking into a police station to report a crime is already classified; the officer does not need to demand deference because the category 'child' carries the deference inside it. A 17-year-old signing a contract is already classified; the bank does not need to refuse because the category 'minor' makes the contract voidable.

Classification is the most universal structural residue. Adultism's classification is the foundational binary — adult/child — that organises every other classification in the framework.

Cisheteropatriarchy (Chapter 5) ranks men above women, but Adultism has already ranked adults above children, so the man ranks above the boy as well. Almost every matrix this framework will study borrows Adultism's grammar of capacity and incapacity.

SECTION 5

5. The Hegemonic Domain: The Ascension Ritual

Is Adultism ascended? The test from Chapter 1: has it achieved Realism — the sense that it is the way reality works, that there is no alternative, that to challenge it is to challenge a hurricane? Has it retroactively rewritten history? Has it produced a stable Intrapersonal Domain?

Yes on all three. Adultism in Nigeria is ascended. It produces all three structural residues including Stratification (so Internalised Domination applies). It has working Canon and Practice mechanisms. The vast majority of Nigerians cannot imagine treating children as full persons — despite the fact that pre-colonial Nigerian societies had age-grade systems that granted real power at puberty, not at 18, and the fact that the 18-year threshold was imported wholesale from English common law during the colonial period.

6.1 Canon — Rewriting History

Canon is the present belief that adult authority has always been so. The origination of the structural residues — the 18-year threshold, the compulsory schooling law, the juvenile court system, the stratified classroom — has been forgotten. The average Nigerian now takes the adult/child binary as natural, eternal, and without alternative.

What is forgotten? The Igbo age-grade system that granted real political power at puberty — the ‘otu ire’ and similar bodies that made decisions for the village. The Tiv age set that organised military and political life by cohort. The Yoruba regberegebe that gave young adults defined roles in the polity. None of these treated puberty as the start of a 6-year ‘minority’ ending at 18. Power was granted at recognition of maturity, not at a fixed chronological threshold.

Also forgotten: that the 18-year threshold came from English common law via the Infant Relief Act 1874 and was extended to colonial Nigeria. That the Children and Young Persons Ordinance 1943 imported the juvenile court model wholesale. That the post-independence replication of these instruments was a deliberate continuation, not an indigenous arrangement. The Child Rights Act 2003 superseded some of these but kept the 18-year threshold intact.

Internalised Domination

Canon produces Internalised Domination because Adultism produces Stratification. The adult’s felt entitlement to obedience, deference, caretaking, time, and the decisions of the young is now natural, automatic, unquestionable. The parent who expects the child to fetch water does not experience this as a demand. They experience it as the natural order.

The teacher who expects students to stand when entering the classroom does not feel he is enforcing. He feels he is being accorded his due. The uncle who expects the niece to greet him first does not feel he is extracting. He feels he is receiving what is owed. The grandparent who expects the grandchild to nurse them does not feel they are extracting caretaking labour. They feel they are being cared for as is right.

The entitlement grows with repetition. The first time the parent entered the room and the child did not stand, the parent felt surprise. The hundredth time, the parent feels outrage. The entitlement has been internalised so deeply that its non-fulfilment registers as injury. Audre Lorde, in *Sister Outsider* (1984), warned feminists that adultism within the movement reproduces the same pattern: the adult feminist who cannot hear the young feminist's voice has internalised the same domination the movement is supposed to dismantle.

Internalised Authority

Canon produces Internalised Authority in the adult enforcer regardless of personal material gain. The mother who slaps the teenage daughter for 'talking back' gains nothing material from the slap. The slap does not extract labour or transfer resources. It enforces a standard — 'children do not talk back' — that the mother has been taught she has a right to enforce.

The teacher who publicly humiliates a student for 'disrespect' gains nothing material. The uncle who punishes a nephew for 'not greeting' gains nothing material. The youth pastor who orders the youth member to 'fast for the week' gains nothing material. The right to enforce feels natural, automatic, and legitimate. That is the Internalised Authority.

Alice Miller, in *For Your Own Good* (1983), called this 'poisonous pedagogy': the transmission of internalised authority from one generation to the next under the cover of 'for the child's own good.' The phrase is the tell. When the enforcement is described as being for the subject's own good, the enforcer is exercising internalised authority, not responding to the subject's expressed need.

Internalised Oppression

Canon produces Internalised Oppression in the young subject and the young witness. The young person is taught that rebellion is impossible, immoral, or pointless. The young witness is taught that dissent is dangerous, divisive, or unproductive. The teaching is silent; it is in the air.

The 12-year-old who is told by a sibling 'that's just how it is' is being disciplined by Canon. The student who is told by a classmate 'you cannot challenge a teacher' is being disciplined by Canon. The teenager who is told by a peer 'you cannot refuse your parent' is being disciplined by Canon. Each internalises the impossibility of refusal.

The deepest form of this is the young person who has absorbed Adultism so thoroughly that they enforce it on themselves. The teenager who says 'I'm just a child' to explain why they cannot act. The university student who says 'my parents will decide' about their own career. The young adult who says 'I cannot question my elders' about an abusive family decision. The rebellion-capable subject has become the self-policing subject.

6.2 Practice — Rewriting Reality

Practice is the second mechanism of the Ascension Ritual. The interpersonal triad is repeated, again and again, until it becomes habit. The adult enforcer forgets they can choose not to enforce. The young subject forgets they can rebel. The young witness forgets they can dissent. The middle-aged parent who has been both subject and enforcer forgets they were ever either.

Pierre Bourdieu called this *habitus* — the sediment of repeated practice in the body, such that the social order no longer needs conscious compliance because it has become the body's default. The Nigerian child who learns to kneel when greeting elders is undergoing Practice for both Adultism and Rankism. The body learns. The mind stops questioning.

By the time the child is twelve, kneeling is reflex. They do not decide to kneel. The body kneels. By adulthood, the young person has performed the compliance, silence, presence, and schedule triads so many thousands of times that the alternative — speaking, refusing, leaving, deciding — feels like a kind of amputation. The body has been trained. Practice has rewritten reality.

Death — Fast and Slow

Practice produces Death. Fast death in Adultism is spectacular: corporal punishment that kills — the child beaten to death by a teacher in 2013 in Lagos, the child flogged to death in a Niger State Quranic school in 2019, the 1991 Lagos boarding school drowning cited in Chapter 2. Fatal exorcisms in Pentecostal churches of 'rebellious' children, especially those labelled as 'witch children' in Akwa Ibom and Cross River States by self-styled deliverance ministries.

Honour killings of teen girls who refused marriages arranged by adults. The ALUU 4 (2012) — four University of Port Harcourt students, all teenagers or young adults, lynched by a community mob acting with the adult-certainty that they were thieves. Boko Haram's child soldiers and child brides, taken from schools and homes in Borno, Yobe, and Adamawa. The 'baby factories' of the South-East where teenage girls are confined and their infants sold.

Slow death in Adultism is quiet. Chronic stress from constant surveillance. Mental health collapse from years of being talked over, dismissed, told 'you'll understand when you're older'. The cumulative erasure of self that produces the 'obedient Nigerian child' who has no internal voice — who reaches adulthood unable to make decisions, unable to know their own preferences, unable to feel their own feelings, because the interior was never given time to form.

Educational trauma that produces lifelong anxiety. The young woman who has been told 'you'll understand when you're older' until she is older and still does not understand herself, because the understanding was never given to her — only the deferral. The young man whose father chose his career for him and who reaches 40 successful in his father's choice and suicidally depressed because he never wanted it. None of these make the news. They are Adultism's quiet tax.

Ruth Wilson Gilmore's definition applies: Adultism produces group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death. The group is 'the young' of every kind. The premature death is fast (corporal punishment, exorcism, lynching, child soldiering) or slow (stress, breakdown, erasure). Every

ascended matrix kills. Adultism kills the youngest, because the youngest have the least capacity to refuse.

SECTION 6

6. When Did Adultism Rewrite History?

The framework's historical question: when did Adultism rewrite history in popular living memory, such that the average Nigerian cannot recall a time when its structural residue was not present? This is not a history of how Adultism was built. It is a diagnosis of when the building was forgotten.

Pre-colonial Nigerian societies had age hierarchies. But the hierarchies were calibrated to puberty, recognition, and cohort, not to a fixed chronological threshold of 18. The Igbo age grade gave political power at recognition of maturity. The Tiv age set organised by cohort without a fixed threshold. The Yoruba regberegbe did the same. Children were not 'children' in the colonial sense until puberty, and after puberty they were candidates for adult responsibility.

Colonial codification imported the English common law 18-year threshold wholesale. The Infant Relief Act 1874 (UK) was extended to colonial Nigeria. The Children and Young Persons Ordinance 1943 established the juvenile court system on the English model. The 1943 Ordinance was the first instrument to define 'child' and 'young person' by fixed chronological age across the colony, displacing the indigenous puberty-based systems.

Post-independence replication continued the displacement. The Children and Young Persons Law of each state replicated the 1943 Ordinance with minor variations. The 1960, 1979, and 1999 constitutions entrenched 18 as the voting age. The Universal Primary Education scheme of 1976 generalised the colonial school structure to every Nigerian child. By the 1980s, the colonial threshold had fully displaced the indigenous arrangements in popular memory.

The tipping point in popular living memory: **circa 1960**. For Nigerians born after 1940 — the independence generation and after — Adultism has 'always been'. They cannot recall a time when the 18-year threshold was not the natural order. The pre-colonial age-grade generation (born ~1880s–1920s) was the last to have living memory of puberty-based adulthood. By independence (1960), that generation had been displaced from policy-making by the colonial-trained elite.

What changed in that moment? Two things. First, the 1943 Ordinance and its 1945 amendments standardised the juvenile court across the colony, so that the colonial definition of 'child' became the legal definition for every Nigerian. Second, the UPE of 1976 put every Nigerian child through a school system organised by the colonial age structure, so that the first generation to grow up entirely inside the new threshold reached adulthood in the 1970s and 1980s. By 1960, though, the threshold was already legally in place, and the question 'is the 18-year line natural?' had already stopped being asked in popular memory.

SECTION 7

7. Fill in the Blank: A Self-Examination

The framework asks two questions of every subject of every ascended matrix. The blanks are for you. They are not rhetorical. The point of the framework is not to understand Adultism in the abstract. It is to locate yourself inside it, so that the next time the triad assembles around you — or around a child in your presence — you can see it.

Question 1: When did Adultism rewrite your reality?

When did the system teach you that you could not rebel? The moment was: _____. The year was: _____. The adult who first made you feel that challenging them was impossible was: _____. The place was: _____. What you wanted to say but did not was: _____. What you did instead was: _____. What you told yourself about why you did not say it was: _____. The body posture you assumed in that moment was: _____. The form of address you used was: _____. What you lost, in that moment, that you have not got back since, was: _____. The age you were was: _____.

Question 2: How is Adultism causing your Death?

How is the system shortening your life right now? The form of Death I am most afraid of from Adultism is (fast/slow): _____. The specific way it is happening in my body is: _____. (For example: the chronic anxiety from years of being unable to question adults; the insomnia from years of swallowing words I wanted to say to my parent; the loss of confidence from years of being talked over; the breakdown I had in 20__ that I have never fully recovered from; the career I never chose because my parent chose it for me; the relationship I lost because I could not stop performing obedience at home; the medical diagnosis I now live with because the stress had nowhere else to go.) The matrix's name for what is happening to me is: _____. My own name for it is: _____.

If you filled in the blanks honestly, you have just located yourself inside Adultism. The next time the triad assembles — the next time the adult demands, the next time the child's body complies, the next time the young person's voice withers — you will be able to see the system moving through you. That sight is the beginning of abolition. And if you are now the adult in the triad, the sight is also the beginning of your refusal to enforce.

SECTION 8

8. Endnotes & References

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Coming Next

Chapter 4 will take up Kinship Normativity — the system that ranks the married, the fertile, and the biologically-related above the unmarried, the childless, and the chosen-family. Kinship Normativity overlaps with Adultism at the point of the family (the parent-child dyad is Adultism’s core triad) and with Cisheteropatriarchy at the point of marriage (Chapter 5). The framework separates them so that the kinship logic specifically — the privileging of blood and marriage above other forms of relation — can be studied and dismantled.

If you are reading this chapter as part of the framework in progress, the order continues: Chapter 5 is Cisheteropatriarchy, Chapter 6 is Religious Dominance / Sectarianism, Chapter 7 is Enclosure, and so on through the Fundamental Matrices. Each chapter follows the same template established in Chapters 2 and 3. The naive approach in the first three domains. The Ascension Ritual in the fourth. The historical memory trace. The fill-in-the-blank. The endnotes. The pattern is now set.